PRACTITIONER PROTOCOL

Lymphatic Drainage

Offer MLD only with training; post-surgical work needs specific training and surgeon clearance. Check your state board rules.

SCREEN

No fever or infection in 24 h, cellulitis, DVT, heart failure, kidney failure or aneurysm. Active cancer: oncologist OK.

CHECK

Post-op: clearance on file, days since surgery, garment, drains. Unmanaged lymphedema: refer to a certified lymphedema therapist.

PRE-SESSION SENT

Bring your surgeon's clearance and compression garment. Use the restroom before you start.

SET UP FIRST ☐ Clearance letter on file ☐ Fresh linens, bolsters, pillows ☐ Hands washed, nails short ☐ Gloves near incisions ☐ Little or no oil ☐ Garment, towels, water

#	STEP	TIME	HOW
1	**Consult & screen**	10 min	Confirm health changes. Post-op: procedure, date, days since surgery.
2	**Consent & clearance**	5 min	Consent signed, surgeon clearance on file. Before photos if agreed.
3	**Position**	3 min	Supine, head and knees supported. Side-lying for back or flanks.
4	**Breathing**	2 min	Slow belly breaths to begin. No abdominal pressure after surgery.
5	**Neck & clavicles**	5 min	Light stationary circles above the collarbones to open the pathway.
6	**Clear nodes**	5 min	Axillary, then inguinal nodes as needed. Skin stretch only, no glide.
7	**Drain toward nodes**	[15–25] min	Near areas first, then farther out. Slow, rhythmic strokes toward nodes.
8	**Around incisions**	[ ] min	Stay [2–3 cm] clear of incisions and drains. Skip firm, hot or red areas.
9	**Finish**	5 min	Repeat node and collarbone strokes. Sit client up slowly.
10	**Garment**	5 min	Help client into compression as the surgeon advised. Smooth, no folds.
11	**Aftercare & rebook**	5 min	Review sheet and card. Rebook on the surgeon's timeline.

ENDPOINT AND SAFETY

- Pressure just enough to stretch skin, no redness
- Never over incisions, drains or hard, hot tissue
- Always work toward nodes, nearer areas first
- Follow the surgeon's plan; stay within your training

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

- Dizzy or faint: stop, lay client flat, raise legs.
- One calf painful, swollen or warm: stop, urgent care.
- Hard, warm or spreading red swelling: don't work it.
- Shortness of breath or chest pain: stop, call 911.
- Incision leaking or opening: gloves, gauze, call surgeon.
- Fever or chills: end the session, refer to a physician.

Note any concern on the record, tell the client to contact their surgeon, and write an incident report.

RECORD FOR THIS SESSION

Procedure · surgery date	Days since surgery	Clearance on file · date	Position · bolsters
Areas treated	Swelling · skin notes	Incisions · drains	Client feedback
Garment fit · stage	Surgeon · phone	Referred to · why	Next visit · initials